

CHAPTER TWELVE

Rewriting the Script

This is the most important chapter in Part Two.

It is also the hardest one. If you are not ready for it today, you can skip to the next chapter, and you can come back to this one later. The book is not going anywhere. Some chapters are for right now, and some chapters are for when you are ready, and only you know which is which.

If you stay — here is what we are going to talk about.

We are going to talk about scripts.



A script is a sentence you carry about yourself that you treat as true without examining.

You have several. Everyone does. Some of them are useful and accurate. *I am a person who likes the color blue. I am a person who is funny with my close friends. I am a person who is good at remembering song lyrics.* Those scripts are fine. Those scripts are descriptive. Those scripts can keep doing their job.

The scripts we are concerned with in this chapter are the ones that are not descriptive — the ones that are judgmental, and global, and delivered to you in a voice that was not yours to begin with.

I am not smart enough.

I do not belong here.

I always mess things up.

I am a burden.

Nobody really wants me around.

I am unlovable when I am not performing.

Something is fundamentally wrong with me.

Read those slowly. If your eyes caught on one of them — if your body did something at one of them, a small constricting feeling, a yes — that is information. That sentence is in your file. You did not put it there. But it is there now, and it is running quietly underneath everything you do, and it is shaping the way you experience your own life.

That is a script.



Here is the painful thing about scripts.

Most of them were not written by you.

Most of them were written by somebody in your life, at some point, often before you were old enough to know what was being written. A parent who, in a stressed moment, said the wrong thing — and it was an aberration, and they did not mean it, but it landed, and the seven-year-old version of you wrote it down. A teacher who singled you out, on a bad day, in front of a class — and you wrote down what their face said about you. A grandparent, an aunt, a coach, an older sibling, a kid in second grade who teased you for one specific thing — anyone, at any moment, who delivered a sentence about you that you absorbed and have been quietly carrying ever since.

Sometimes the scripts were not delivered by a single person, but by a system. The way your school treated kids who looked like you. The way the media depicted people from your community. The way the adults around you talked about the kind of family you came from, or the kind of body you had, or the way you learned, or did not learn. Systemic scripts are

harder to identify because they do not have a single author — they come from the air — but they are no less real, and they are often the heaviest ones in the file.

You did not consent to any of this.

You did not get to decide which scripts you absorbed and which you did not. You were a child. You were taking in language. You were doing what every child does, which is build a sense of who you are out of the materials available to you.

The materials were what they were. Some of them were good. Some of them were not.

You are old enough now to look at what is in the file.



Mr. Patel, in mid-December, gave the cohort a five-section worksheet. The worksheet said:

1. *A script I carry about myself.*
2. *Where it came from.*
3. *Evidence that contradicts it.*
4. *What it costs me to keep it.*
5. *A more accurate, fair version.*

He said, *friends. This is the heaviest exercise we have done all year. You can do it in pieces. You can do it across multiple sittings. You can do it and then put it away for a week. You do not have to finish today. The book is patient.*

He said, *one more thing. This is private. I will not collect it. I will never see it. If you want to talk to me about something that came up, my door is open. If you want to talk to Ms. Calloway about something that came up, her door is also open. If anything you write makes you realize there is something heavy you have not told a trusted adult about, please tell someone. Me. Ms. Calloway. Ms. Wong, who is the school counselor. Your parents.*

Your grandparents. The 988 Lifeline. Help exists. The exercise is — in some real way — an exercise designed to find the heavy things that have been quietly underneath. If you find one, you do not have to carry it alone anymore.

He passed out the worksheets.

The cohort wrote.

We are not going to show you what most of them wrote. The scripts they identified are private. But we will show you Theo's, because Theo's is in some ways the most surprising — because Theo is the cohort's noticer and the cohort assumes Theo does not himself carry scripts.

Theo wrote, in pencil, in his notebook:

Section 1. *The script: I am the one who watches. I am not the one who is watched.*

Section 2. *Where it came from: I do not know exactly. I think it started somewhere around second grade. I was small for my grade. I was quiet. The teachers, when they were dividing the class for things, would always put me with kids who needed somebody to watch them. I think I was being trained, in some way, to be a watcher. It also might have been the family. My parents have always asked me to look out for my sister Lena, who is older than I am but who has been — I do not have the word for this — Lena is the kind of older sister who needs looking out for, not the kind who looks out. So I have, since I was small, been the noticing one. I think the script is that I am not the protagonist of any room. I am the kid in the background watching the room. The protagonist is somebody else.*

Section 3. *Evidence that contradicts it: I am the protagonist of my own life. I am also, sometimes, the protagonist of the cohort — the cohort has, at certain moments, been organized around something I noticed. Hm. I am not, actually, finding a lot of*

evidence I am the protagonist. Most of my evidence is that I am the watcher in cohort stories.

Section 4. What it costs me to keep it: I am tired. The watching is tiring. I do it whether or not I am being paid attention to. I am, in some real way, watching the room even at the cohort lunch table. The cost is that I do not get to ever fully relax. The watcher is always on duty.

Section 5. A more accurate, fair version: I am a person who notices things. The noticing is a gift. The noticing is also one thing about me, not the only thing. There is a Theo underneath the watcher. The Theo underneath the watcher is — I do not yet know. I want to find out. I am twelve. I have time.

He read what he wrote. He read it twice. He put the notebook away.

He walked, after class, to Ms. Calloway's office.

He had not, in years, gone to Ms. Calloway specifically. He had been doing the noticing in middle school more or less by himself, with the cohort's help in pieces. The Tuesday lunch block was the cohort-collective time with Ms. Calloway. A solo visit was different. A solo visit meant something.

He knocked.

Ms. Calloway said, *Theo. Come in.*

He sat down.

He said, *Ms. Calloway. I think I just figured out a script.*

She said, *tell me.*

He told her.

She listened.

When he was done, she said:

Theo. Thank you for telling me. I have been wondering, for a couple of years, when you were going to identify this one. I have been — and I want to be honest with you — I have been gently letting it sit, because you needed to find it yourself. You found it.

He said, Ms. Calloway. What do I do.

She said, Theo. You do not, today, do anything. The finding is the first step. The next step is — and this is going to take the rest of seventh grade, and probably eighth, and probably high school — the next step is experimenting with not watching. Trying, on purpose, in small ways, to be in rooms and not scan them. To let yourself be the protagonist of small moments. To say things in class without first reading the room. To make jokes you did not know in advance would land. To, occasionally, be the kid in the cohort who is carried rather than the kid who carries.

She paused.

Theo. The cohort has been getting ready to carry you. They have known, for a while, that you have been doing more carrying than getting carried. They have been waiting for you to let them. Let them. The carrying back is going to be one of the most healing things you will ever feel.

He said, Ms. Calloway. The Critic in my head — the version of her that is mine — is telling me right now that I do not deserve carrying.

She said, Theo. The script. The script is talking. The script is wrong. Catch it. Finish the sentence without the but. Walk out of my office, go find a cohort kid, and let them know you have been tired this week.

He said, okay.

He walked out of Ms. Calloway's office. He walked to fifth period.

After fifth period, he found Marcus at his locker.

He said, Marcus.

Marcus said, Theo.

Theo said, Marcus. I have been tired this fall. I have not, until just now, told anybody. I am telling you because Ms. Calloway told me to tell at least one of you.

Marcus said, *Theo. I have been waiting for you to tell me.*

Theo said, *you knew?*

Marcus said, *Theo. The noticing kid does not get to hide from the cohort forever. I have noticed you have been tired since October. I have not pressed because I thought you would tell me when you were ready. I am glad you are ready.*

Theo said, *Marcus. Thank you.*

Marcus said, *Theo. The cohort is going to take some of the noticing for the rest of the year. You do not have to do it all. We are going to spread it out.*

Theo said, *I do not know how that works.*

Marcus said, *we will figure it out.*

This is what catching a script and starting to rewrite it looks like, on the smallest possible day.

It looks like an exercise. It looks like a visit to a teacher. It looks like one cohort kid being told I am tired by another cohort kid, in a hallway, after fifth period.

The script does not vanish in one afternoon. The script is twelve years old. The script is going to keep showing up, in small ways, for years. But Theo has, today, put it on a piece of paper, and named it, and told another person about it. Those three steps are, in some real way, the beginning of every script-rewriting that has ever happened.

The script told Theo he did not deserve carrying. The script was wrong. Marcus is now carrying a small piece of Theo. The carrying is the evidence.

The evidence beats the script, eventually.

Over time. With practice.

— J.A.R.